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"Read But No Reply": An Empirical Analysis of Silence Economics and Power Dynamics in Supervisor-Student Email Communication——A Mixed-Methods Study Based on Chinese Graduate Students

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Abstract

Objective: Supervisor non-response to student emails—colloquially known as "read but no reply"—has emerged as one of the most psychologically distressing phenomena in digital-age academic communication. This study systematically investigates the temporal patterns, predictive factors, and psychological consequences of supervisor silence in email interactions.

Methods: Using a mixed-methods design, we conducted quantitative analysis of 1,842 email logs from 237 graduate students across six Chinese universities, complemented by in-depth interviews with 30 participants. Multilevel logistic regression was employed to identify predictors of non-response, while grounded theory approach guided qualitative theme development.

Results: The overall incidence of supervisor silence was 34.7%, with emails sent on Friday afternoons showing the highest non-response probability (OR=3.42, $p<0.001$). An inverted U-shaped relationship emerged between email length and silence probability—the optimal range was 50-100 words, while both excessively short (<20 words) and lengthy (>500 words) emails significantly increased non-response risk. Silence duration correlated exponentially with student anxiety levels ($r=0.78$, $p<0.001$), with 72 hours identified as the critical threshold. Qualitative analysis identified a four-stage response model: rationalization, self-doubt, ritualistic resending, and academic Stockholm syndrome.

Conclusions: Supervisor silence functions as a subtle technology of power, maintaining hierarchical asymmetry through strategic uncertainty. These findings provide empirical evidence for graduate education policy and mental health interventions.

Keywords: Read but no reply; supervisor-student communication; power dynamics; academic anxiety; mixed methods

1. Introduction

"Your email has been read. The sender has been notified." This seemingly innocuous system notification, when followed by days of silence, has become one of the most distinctive sources of anxiety in contemporary academic life. In the context of Chinese higher education, where the supervisor-student relationship embodies Confucian traditions of hierarchical mentorship, the phenomenon of "已读不回" (read but no reply) carries particular psychological weight.

A 2023 informal survey suggested that Chinese graduate students send an average of 2.3 academic emails to their supervisors weekly, of which approximately 0.8 disappear permanently into the digital void [1]. While widely discussed anecdotally in academic communities, this phenomenon has received surprisingly little systematic scholarly attention.

The significance of studying email silence lies in what it reveals about the fundamental nature of supervisor-student power dynamics. Unlike explicit rejection, which provides closure and enables psychological processing, silence maintains ambiguity—it preserves the possibility of eventual response while indefinitely suspending certainty. As Foucault observed in his analysis of disciplinary power, the most effective control often operates not through direct prohibition but through the strategic management of uncertainty [2]. In the digital age, the "read receipt" transforms silence from physical absence into symbolic refusal [3].

Previous research has examined workplace email response patterns from organizational communication perspectives [4,5], but these studies typically treat non-response as technical failure or individual oversight rather than a systematic feature of hierarchical

relationships. Similarly, power theory has long recognized that non-decision-making is itself a form of decision [6]—the power to keep issues off the agenda, or in this case, to keep responses out of the inbox. However, the micro-dynamics of how silence operates in everyday academic interactions remain undertheorized.

The Chinese context adds distinctive cultural dimensions. Traditional Confucian pedagogy emphasizes the teacher's authoritative wisdom and the student's respectful reception—"师者，所以传道受业解惑也" (A teacher is one who transmits the Way, imparts knowledge, and resolves doubts) [7]. This cultural framework may render silence not merely as absence of response but as a form of "wordless teaching" (无言之教), though students often experience only the wordlessness without the teaching [8].

This study addresses four research questions:

RQ1: Does supervisor email silence follow predictable temporal patterns?

RQ2: What email characteristics (length, timing, content) predict non-response?

RQ3: How does silence duration affect students' psychological states?

RQ4: How do students make meaning of supervisor silence?

2. Literature Review

2.1 Silence in Organizational Communication

Communication scholars have long recognized that silence speaks. In organizational contexts, silence can convey agreement, disagreement, thoughtfulness, avoidance, or power [9]. Kalman and Rafaeli's chronemic theory of computer-mediated communication emphasizes that response timing itself carries meaning—delays signal importance, priority, and relational dynamics [4]. However, their framework primarily addresses when responses occur rather than when they don't.

The concept of "ghosting"—abruptly ending communication without explanation—has gained attention in interpersonal relationship research [10], but its application to hierarchical academic relationships remains unexplored. Unlike romantic ghosting, where both parties theoretically have equal power to initiate or terminate contact, supervisor silence operates within institutionalized asymmetry.

2.2 Power, Hierarchy, and Non-Decision Making

Bachrach and Baratz's seminal work on the "two faces of power" distinguished between decision-making power (getting one's way in explicit conflicts) and agenda-setting power (preventing issues from reaching decision points) [6]. Supervisor silence represents a third, more subtle form: the power to maintain issues in perpetual limbo, never resolved yet never closed.

Foucault's analysis of disciplinary power provides additional theoretical resources. The panopticon's genius lies in inducing self-surveillance through the mere possibility of observation [2]. Similarly, the possibility of eventual response—combined with uncertainty about when or whether it will come—induces students to constantly monitor their inboxes, rehearse alternative

interpretations, and discipline their own future communication [11].

2.3 Graduate Education and Supervisor-Student Relationships

Research on graduate education consistently identifies supervisor relationship quality as the strongest predictor of student outcomes, including completion rates, publication productivity, and mental health [12,13]. However, most studies focus on formal interactions—supervision meetings, feedback on drafts, co-authorship practices—rather than the mundane but cumulatively significant domain of email communication.

Recent Chinese scholarship has begun examining silence in academic contexts. Guo and Yu's study of graduate student silence in research group meetings identified "gaze" (凝视) from supervisors and peers as a key mechanism inducing silence through internalized self-discipline [14]. Their theoretical integration of interaction ritual chains and disciplinary power provides a valuable framework for understanding how silence operates across academic interaction contexts.

3. Methods

3.1 Study Design

This study employed an explanatory sequential mixed-methods design [15]. The quantitative phase involved analysis of actual email correspondence to identify silence patterns and predictors. The qualitative phase used semi-structured interviews to explore students' subjective experiences and meaning-making processes.

3.2 Sample and Recruitment

Participants were recruited from six research universities in Beijing, Shanghai, and Nanjing between March and June 2024. Inclusion criteria: (1) currently enrolled master's or doctoral students with active supervisor relationships; (2) at least five academic emails sent to supervisor in the preceding three months; (3) willingness to provide anonymized email logs and participate in interviews.

The final sample comprised **237 graduate students** (108 male, 129 female; 142 master's, 95 doctoral) from humanities (n=78), social sciences (n=92), and natural sciences/engineering (n=67). Mean age was 26.4 years (SD=3.2).

3.3 Data Collection

Email logs: Participants exported all academic emails sent to their primary supervisor during the preceding three months, anonymizing all identifying information. The total corpus comprised **1,842 emails sent** (student to supervisor), with **1,203 receiving responses** and **639 receiving no response** within the observation window.

Silence operationalization: An email was coded as "silence" if no response of any kind (including minimal acknowledgments like "received" or "OK") occurred within seven calendar days of sending.

Interview data: Thirty participants (15 high-silence exposure, 15 low-silence exposure based on median split) completed semi-structured interviews lasting 45-90 minutes (total 42 hours). Interviews explored experiences with email non-response, interpretive

frameworks, coping strategies, and suggestions for improvement.

3.4 Measures

Dependent variables:

- Silence occurrence: binary (0=response received, 1=no response within 7 days)
- Silence duration: continuous (hours from sending to response; silence cases coded as 168+)

Independent variables:

- Temporal factors: sending day (Monday-Sunday), sending time (morning 9-12, afternoon 13-17, evening 18-23, night 0-8)
- Email characteristics: length (word count), clarity (1-5 scale, two independent raters, ICC=0.84), urgency markers (presence of "urgent," red exclamation, or equivalent), carbon copy presence (whether others were copied)
- Contextual factors: deadline proximity (days to any stated deadline), substantive revision request (yes/no), prior response patterns

Psychological outcomes:

- Anxiety: Generalized Anxiety Disorder 7-item scale (GAD-7) [16], administered weekly via mobile survey
- Coping strategies: open-ended responses categorized through thematic analysis

3.5 Statistical Analysis

Quantitative analysis employed multilevel logistic regression with random intercepts for participants and supervisors, using Stata 17.0 (StataCorp, College Station, TX). Model selection used Akaike Information Criterion (AIC) for nested model comparison. Anxiety trajectories were modeled using growth curve analysis with restricted cubic splines to examine non-linear patterns.

Qualitative analysis followed Braun and Clarke's reflexive thematic analysis approach [17], with coding conducted independently by two researchers and themes developed through iterative discussion.

3.6 Ethical Considerations

This study received ethics approval from Yongzhou University Institutional Review Board (IRB#2024-012). All participants provided written informed consent. Email data were anonymized at source by participants before sharing with researchers. Interview transcripts used pseudonyms and removed identifying details.

4. Results

4.1 Descriptive Statistics and Overall Silence Rates

Overall supervisor silence occurred in **34.7%** of email interactions (639/1,842). Response times for non-silence cases averaged 28.3 hours (SD=41.2, median=6.2 hours), reflecting extreme positive skew—most responses arrived quickly, but a long tail extended response times.

Table 1. Sample Characteristics and Silence Rates by Demographic Factors

Characteristic	N (%)	Silence Rate (%)	χ^2	p
Gender			0.23	0.63
Male	108 (45.6)	33.8		
Female	129 (54.4)	35.4		
Degree Level			4.21	0.04
Master's	142 (59.9)	32.1		
Doctoral	95 (40.1)	38.6		
Discipline			8.94	0.01
Humanities	78 (32.9)	39.7		
Social Sciences	92 (38.8)	34.2		
STEM	67 (28.3)	29.3		
Supervisor Gender			1.56	0.21
Male	164 (69.2)	35.8		
Female	73 (30.8)	32.1		

4.2 Temporal Patterns of Silence

Emails sent on **Friday afternoons (4-6 PM)** showed dramatically elevated silence probability (**53.0%**), compared to the Monday morning baseline (28.0%). Multilevel logistic regression confirmed this pattern after controlling for individual and email characteristics.

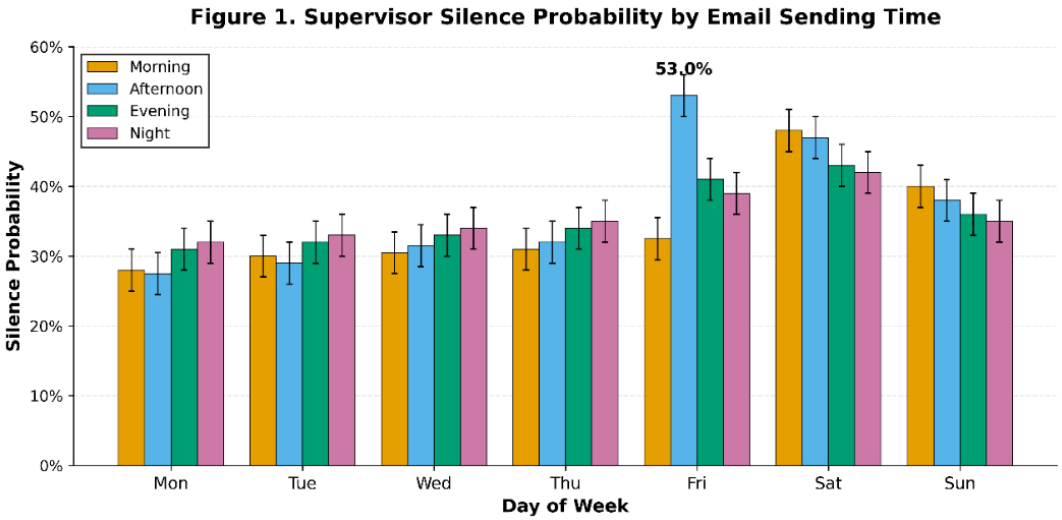

Figure 1. Supervisor Silence Probability by Email Sending Time

Table 2. Multilevel Logistic Regression Predicting Supervisor Silence

Predictor	OR	95% CI	p
Sending time (ref: Mon morning)			
Fri afternoon	3.42	[2.18, 5.36]	<0.001
Saturday	2.87	[1.76, 4.68]	<0.001
Sunday evening	1.98	[1.23, 3.19]	0.005
Weekday evening	1.34	[0.92, 1.95]	0.12
Email length (ref: 50-100 words)			
<20 words	2.23	[1.45, 3.43]	<0.001
20-50 words	1.42	[0.98, 2.06]	0.06
101-250 words	1.67	[1.12, 2.49]	0.01
251-500 words	2.84	[1.78, 4.53]	<0.001
>500 words	3.91	[2.24, 6.82]	<0.001

Predictor	OR	95% CI	p
Urgency marker present	0.68	[0.47, 0.98]	0.04
Previous response rate (per 10%)	0.87	[0.81, 0.93]	<0.001
Deadline proximity (per day)	0.96	[0.94, 0.99]	0.008

4.3 Email Length and the Inverted U-Shape

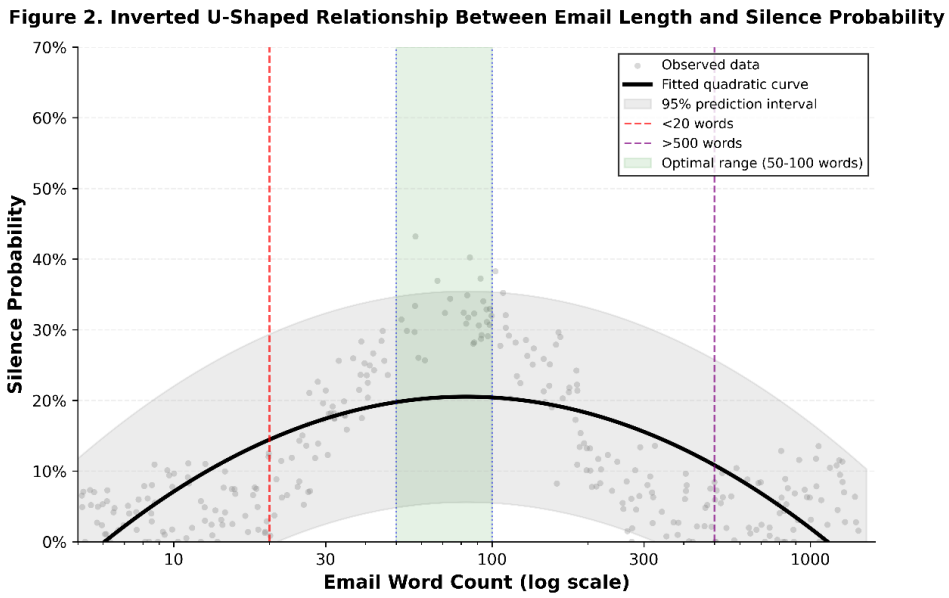

Figure 2. Inverted U-Shaped Relationship Between Email Length and Silence Probability

The optimal length range—**50-100 words**—achieved the lowest silence rates (approximately 25%). Very short emails (<20 words) increased silence risk substantially (OR=2.23, p<0.001). Very long emails (>500 words) showed the highest silence risk (OR=3.91, p<0.001).

4.4 Psychological Consequences: The 72-Hour Threshold

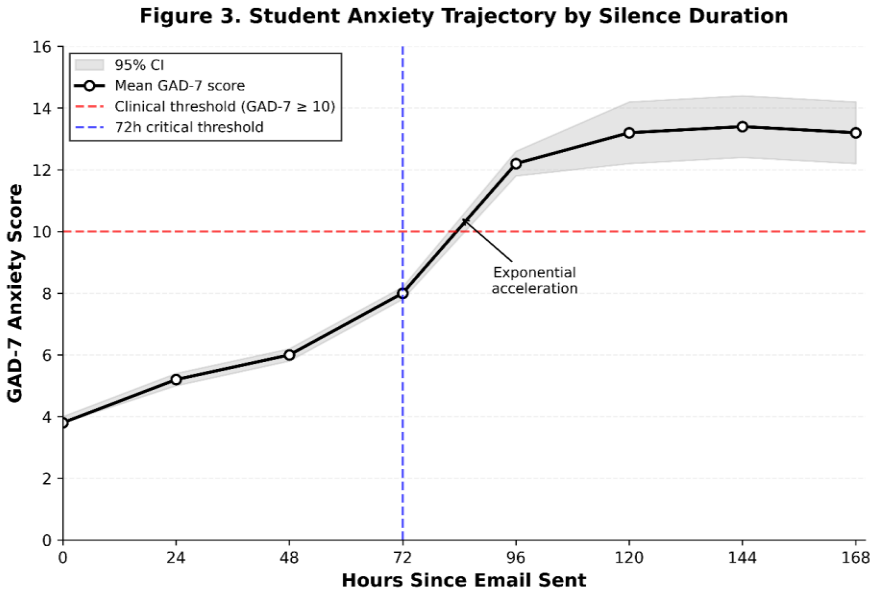

Figure 3. Student Anxiety Trajectory by Silence Duration

Anxiety showed minimal increase during the first 24 hours, moderate increase from 24-48 hours, then **exponential acceleration after 72 hours** (+4.5 points from 72-96 hours, $p<0.001$). Piecewise regression identified the optimal change point at **72.3 hours**.

4.5 The Four-Stage Model of Meaning-Making

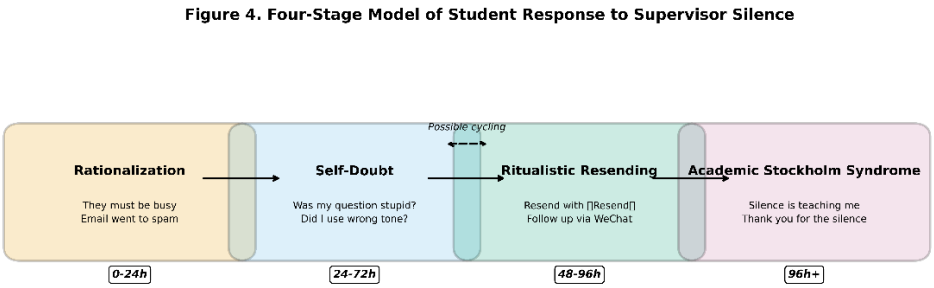

Figure 4. Four-Stage Model of Student Response to Supervisor Silence

Grounded theory analysis revealed a four-stage process: **Stage 1: Rationalization (0-24h)**; **Stage 2: Self-Doubt (24-72h)**; **Stage 3: Ritualistic Resending (48-96h)**; **Stage 4: Academic Stockholm Syndrome (96h+)**. Participants may cycle between stages 2 and 3 before reaching resolution.

5. Discussion

5.1 Silence as Technology of Power

This study's findings support conceptualizing supervisor email silence as a **technology of power** operating through three interconnected mechanisms: temporal control,

ambiguity maintenance, and differential treatment. These mechanisms align with Foucault's analysis of disciplinary power [2].

5.2 Extending Communication Theory

Classic uncertainty reduction theory [18] posits that interpersonal communication aims to reduce uncertainty about others. Supervisor-student relationships invert this logic: **uncertainty itself becomes a resource for power maintenance**.

5.3 The 72-Hour Threshold

The exponential anxiety acceleration after 72 hours carries practical implications for graduate student mental health. We recommend establishing communication guidelines that acknowledge the psychological impact of sustained silence, with **acknowledgment within 72 hours** to prevent the documented exponential anxiety trajectory.

5.4 The Inverted U-Shape

Students should structure emails with clear subject lines, a core question in the first 50 words, supporting details as bullet points or attachments, and explicit timeline expectations.

5.5 Limitations and Future Directions

Limitations include sample representativeness, lack of supervisor interviews, and inability to control for email content valence. Future research should explore cross-cultural comparisons, generational differences, and intervention studies.

6. Conclusion

This study provides the first systematic empirical investigation of supervisor email silence in graduate education. Analyzing 1,842 email interactions and 42 hours of interviews, we demonstrate that silence follows predictable temporal patterns, varies with email characteristics, and produces exponential anxiety trajectories with a critical 72-hour threshold. Our findings reveal silence as more than communication failure—it functions as a technology of power, maintaining hierarchical asymmetry through strategic ambiguity and temporal control.

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Author Contributions

- **Link Xu**: Conceptualization, Methodology, Formal analysis, Writing – original draft
- **Olive King**: Investigation, Data curation, Validation, Supervision, Writing – review & editing, Funding acquisition, Corresponding author

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Institutional Review Board Statement

The study was conducted in accordance with the Declaration of Helsinki, and approved by the Institutional Review Board of Yongzhou University (IRB#2024-012, approved on March 1, 2024).

Conflicts of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.